GLADYS PORTER EARLY COLLEGE HIGH SCHOOL
TEAM LUNOVA · ORTHOPRINT

NASA HUNCH 2026–27 · Lunar Splint Design Challenge

TEAM #

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Gertrudis Hernandez
Jose P. Hernandez
Nancy De La Cruz

1 THE PROBLEM

A lunar base is days from a hospital, and launching splints in every size wastes mass (~$1,000 per gram). It needs a custom splint it can print on demand from a scan.

$1M	1/6 g	−1–2%
launch cost per kilogram	lunar gravity	bone density per month

LATERAL ANKLE LIGAMENT TEAR
Outer ankle · heals in 3–26 weeks · caused by uneven flooring

CRITERIA

Comfortable · One-handed · Durable 6 mo. · Safe · Custom fit · Lunar innovation

CONSTRAINTS

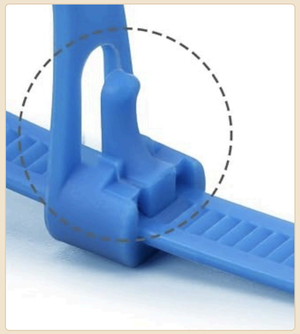
1/6 gravity · Bone loss · No hospital · ~$1,000 / gram · Printer limits · Little space

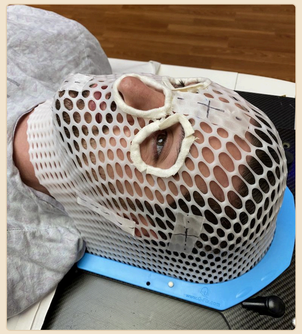
2 RESEARCH



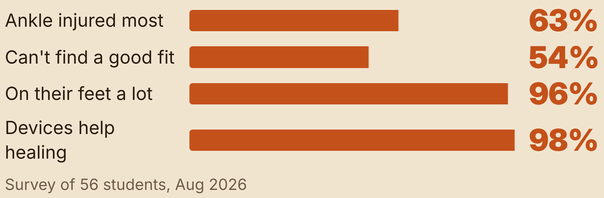
SAM splint from our trainer


Splinted ankle, wrapped


Reusable zip tie: closure idea


Mesh mask molded to one person: scan-to-fit idea

> *"A splint allows almost no motion. Make it firm and tight."*
> School athletic trainer, 9/18



Survey of 56 students, Aug 2026

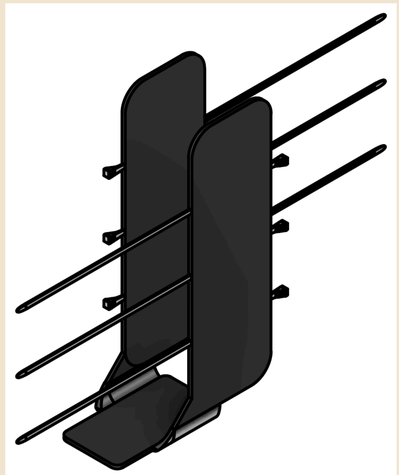
OUR DESIGN: PROS AND CONS

+ Breathable
+ Sanitary
+ Adjustable

− Uses a lot of material

INNOVATION 1
SINGLE-PIECE RATCHET CLOSURE
Zip-tie straps, no loose parts, one hand.

FEATURE
CUSTOM FIT
Printed from a scan of the leg.


Updated 3D CAD · Jose P. Hernandez, 10/16/2026

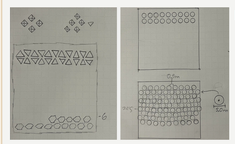
INNOVATION 2
INTEGRATED HYGIENE
Clean and check it over weeks of wear.

INNOVATION 3
THERMAL PHASE DESIGN
TPU flexible to fit, firm to hold.

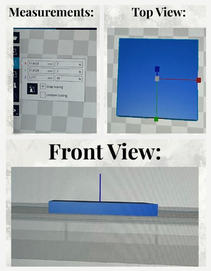
3 FROM CONCEPT 1 TO OUR UPDATED DESIGN



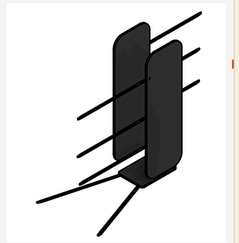
CONCEPTS 1 & 2
Cast, then buckle
A cast is not a splint, so we switched. Concept 2 added a buckle. · Nancy



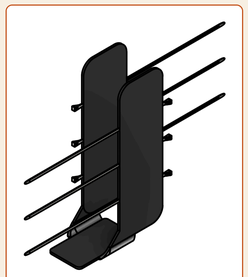
TEST
Hole patterns
Triangles failed, circles bent too much, so the wall went solid. · Gertrudis



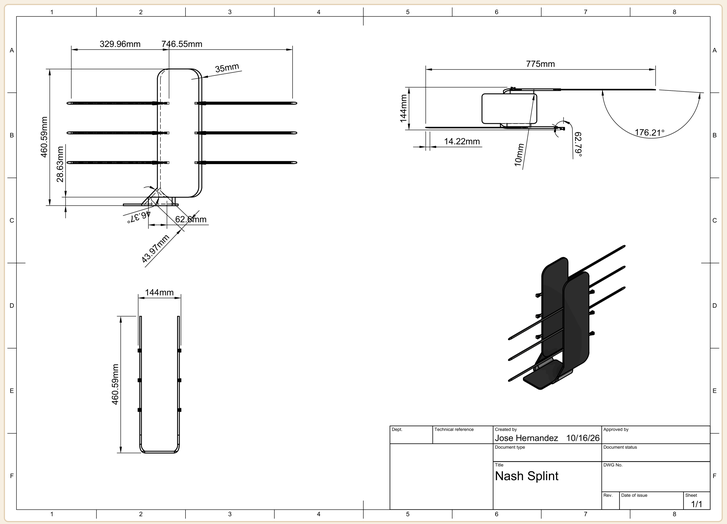
CAD
Test samples
51.6 × 51.6 × 5.2 mm squares to compare materials.



BEFORE
Preliminary design
Our first CAD: latch + zip-tie straps in an X.



NOW
Updated design
We changed the CAD. New drawing, 10/16/2026.



Updated detail drawing with measurements (mm), Jose P. Hernandez, 10/16/2026

PARTS AND SIZES

Side plates (2)
35 mm rounded corners, 144 mm apart

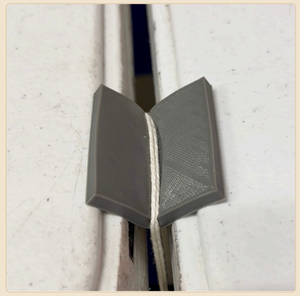
Base plate
Joins the two side plates at the bottom

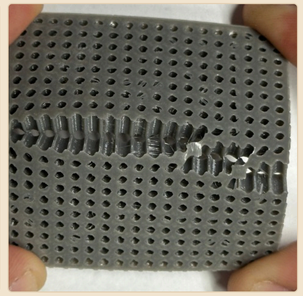
Straps
One-piece zip-tie style, X wrap

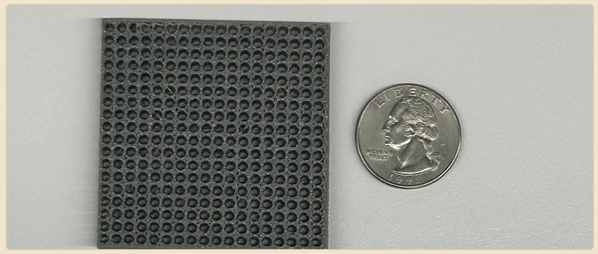
Overall
460.59 mm tall

ATTACH A PHOTO OF OUR 70% PROTOTYPE HERE

3 TESTING


Hanging-weight test


Printed sample, split


TPU sample with quarter

PETG, holes: broke after bending	REJECTED
TPU, holes: layers split at 2,550 g	REJECTED
Triangle holes: did not hold	REJECTED
Solid TPU: firm, moulds slightly	CHOSEN
Straps at key points: ankle stayed still	CHOSEN

MATERIALS

PLA
Prototype 1

ABS
Prototype 2

TPU
Prototype 3 · flexes, firm when solid

~~PETG~~
Broke when bent

CF-PEEK
Goal flight material

NEXT STEPS

→Strap thickness and break load
→Filament softening temperature
→Re-test small vents
→Mass and print time from final CAD

Sept 24	Oct 21–22	Nov–Dec	Mid-April
Solid prototype	PDR, Mercedes	Prototype #2	NASA HUNCH evaluation

4 WEBSITE & VIDEOS

Project website
Notebook, survey, CAD and testing

PROTOTYPE VIDEO QR

Prototype video
2 minutes

PRESENTATION VIDEO QR

Presentation video
2 minutes

A NASA HUNCH 2026–27 student design project. Not endorsed by NASA. Not a medical device.